Positive, monotone, and convex Gaussian process regression with Laplacian eigenfunctions

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Abstract

We study how to condition an existing Hilbert space Gaussian process (HSGP) expansion on positivity, monotonicity, or convexity throughout an interval. The expansion has Gaussian coefficients whose variances are given by the kernel's spectral density. At fixed covariance and noise parameters, we retain this coefficient law and represent each complete interval event as a threshold on one coefficient. Integrating out that coefficient gives a strongly log-concave marginal posterior with a normal survival weight, while conditional truncated normal sampling recovers the full constrained law. The construction also covers joint restrictions within the finite expansion. For individual restrictions, we characterize the thresholds through polynomial equations and bound posterior error from conservative numerical evaluation in total variation. Under spectral regularity, the conditioned finite posteriors converge in quadratic Wasserstein distance to the corresponding conditioned underlying GP posteriors as the computational interval expands and higher frequencies are retained. This convergence controls uniform discrepancies in the response and derivatives through the constrained order. Mercury lidar and leaf light-response applications illustrate the consequences for derivative inference.

Keywords: Bayesian regression, continuum constraint, derivative inference, Gaussian process, Hilbert space approximation

1 Introduction

Scientific information about a response often concerns its sign or how it changes over an interval. Positivity restricts the response itself, while monotonicity and convexity restrict its slope and curvature when the corresponding derivatives exist. These properties need not be visible in noisy observations, so a Gaussian process (GP) that describes the data closely can still assign probability to curves that conflict with the proposed scientific model. We therefore seek a posterior law that imposes the restriction throughout a specified interval while retaining joint uncertainty about the response and its derivatives.

The Hilbert space GP (HSGP) approximation of Solin and Särkkä (2020) represents the process by a finite expansion in Laplacian eigenfunctions on an interval extending beyond the region of interest. This extension, called padding, is used to reduce boundary effects, while the rank, or number of retained functions, controls the finest variation represented for a given computational interval (Riutort-Mayol et al., 2023). The basis functions are independent of the covariance kernel and its

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parameters. The kernel enters through spectral values that determine Gaussian coefficient variances, allowing the same basis and its analytic derivatives to be reused across covariance specifications. Shape restrictions, however, concern the entire curve obtained by summing the oscillatory basis functions. Their validity is not determined by the signs of the individual coefficients, and checking a finite set of locations can miss a violation between them. The question addressed here is how to condition this spectral model on the complete interval restriction while retaining its basis and kernel-derived Gaussian coefficient law.

Our construction begins with positivity. A random intercept shifts the whole curve above zero when it exceeds the negative minimum of the spectral part. The same argument extends to monotonicity and convexity whenever the retained span contains a direction with a uniformly positive selected derivative, because a sufficiently large coefficient along that direction makes the full curve satisfy the restriction for any fixed values of the remaining coefficients. Thus the continuum event becomes a lower bound on one Gaussian coefficient, with a threshold determined by the remaining coefficients. Under Gaussian observations, integrating out that coefficient gives an explicit marginal posterior weighted by a normal survival probability. A subsequent draw from its truncated conditional normal restores the full conditioned law. This representation makes continuum conditioning available within the HSGP expansion without changing the probability model through a nonlinear transformation of the curve.

1.1 Related work and contributions

Conditioning Gaussian processes on inequalities is an established approach to shape-constrained regression. The survey of Swiler et al. (2020) distinguishes constraints imposed at selected locations from constructions that restrict an entire finite-dimensional function space. In particular, Da Veiga and Marrel (2012) formulate bound, monotonicity, and convexity restrictions as conditioning events for a GP. To compute constrained predictive means, they replace restrictions over an interval by inequalities at finitely many selected locations and evaluate or approximate moments of the resulting truncated multivariate normal law. Their later work develops a strategy for selecting these locations (Da Veiga and Marrel, 2020). The target of our construction is also a conditioned Gaussian law. The distinction is that, within a retained HSGP expansion, we characterize the restriction over every location in the interval before computing its posterior law.

Global derivative restrictions and derivative inference have precedents in Bayesian regression, where piecewise-linear isotonic models permit flat and increasing segments (Neelon and Dunson, 2004), while smooth parameterizations and regression splines give other monotone priors (Shively et al., 2009). Ordered Bernstein coefficients combine global monotonicity with variable selection or clustering (Curtis and Ghosh, 2011; Wilson et al., 2020), with the aerosol analysis of Wilson et al. (2020) illustrating derivative inference through the derivative of a monotone differential-pressure curve. For convex regression, maxima of random affine functions address multivariate inputs and permit nonsmooth surfaces (Hannah and Dunson, 2011), for which support and posterior consistency results are available. Integrating squared GPs provides smooth shape restrictions (Lenk and Choi, 2017), with spectral constructions also available for grouped data (Lenk et al., 2024). These approaches establish that global shape information and derivative inference can be incorporated in Bayesian regression in several ways. They also make the choice of probability model substantive: transforming or integrating a GP generally gives a different law from conditioning a specified Gaussian model on a shape event.

The closest whole-interval constructions condition finite Gaussian expansions using bases chosen to express global shape restrictions as coefficient inequalities (Maatouk and Bay, 2017). These constraints hold throughout the domain, and subsequent work develops general linear inequalities,

noisy observations, multiple constraints, and smooth bases (López-Lopera et al., 2018, 2020; Maatouk et al., 2025a). Within this line of work, Ray et al. (2020) combine smooth relaxations of coefficient constraints with elliptical slice sampling and circulant embedding, while Gaussian simulation on correlated subdomains addresses larger problems (Maatouk et al., 2025b). Our construction shares the aim of conditioning a finite Gaussian model on a global restriction. Its distinctive task is to characterize that restriction in the Laplacian–Dirichlet spectral space while retaining its kernel-derived Gaussian coefficient law. The oscillatory basis requires a different description of the constraint. Laplacian spectral expansions themselves also have precedents, including their use for boundary conditions discussed by Swiler et al. (2020).

Other GP approaches impose derivative signs at virtual locations (Riihimäki and Vehtari, 2010; Agrell, 2019), use randomized optimization for constrained inference (Zhang et al., 2026), or project GP curves onto the monotone-function space (Lin and Dunson, 2014). Virtual-location restrictions provide a finite approximation to an interval constraint, whereas projection defines the fitted curve by a separate map. Table 1 locates the present construction among the approaches most directly related to its conditioning target. The table separates whether a restriction holds throughout the finite model's interval from whether that finite model approximates a conditioned underlying GP.

Approach	Model and imposed restriction	Computed object	Interval scope
Da Veiga–Marrel	GP conditioned on inequalities at selected locations	Constrained predictive moments from a truncated Gaussian law	The selected-location event approximates the interval event
Maatouk–Bay and extensions	Finite Gaussian expansion in a basis chosen for coefficient inequalities	Conditioned coefficient law and predictive summaries	Coefficient inequalities ensure shape throughout the finite expansion's domain
Present paper	HSGP expansion with its kernel-derived Gaussian coefficient law conditioned on an interval event	Survival-weighted marginal law and conditional reconstruction of the full coefficient law	Exact interval event at finite rank and a conditioned-GP limit for individual restrictions

Table 1: Conditioning targets and interval guarantees for related approaches. The descriptions concern the finite models used for computation. The conditioned-GP limit in the last row requires the spectral assumptions and increasing padding and frequency cutoff stated in Theorem 2.

The first contribution is a common representation for positivity, monotonicity, and convexity, together with explicit directions and sufficient rank and padding conditions for each case. Sign reversal gives the corresponding nonpositive, nonincreasing, and concave models. The representation also applies to joint restrictions whenever the retained span contains a direction with the required signs at all selected derivative orders. We give conditions on the HSGP direction coefficients and threshold reductions covering all 26 combinations without opposing constraints.

To evaluate the thresholds for the individual constraints, a cosine transformation reduces the search for stationary locations to polynomial equations, with endpoints, repeated roots, and constant cases included. These characterizations make the thresholds amenable to global evaluation. The resulting marginal posterior is strongly log-concave in whitened coordinates, and a total variation bound quantifies the change in its reconstructed law when a conservative numerical threshold is used. The computational cost is a global maximization at each target evaluation, so the representation offers an alternative to bases with direct coefficient inequalities, rather than a general efficiency advantage.

The second contribution connects finite continuum conditioning to conditioning the underlying GP. Covariance approximation alone does not settle this question because the indicator of a sign event is discontinuous at curves that touch its boundary. For each individual constraint, we establish a null boundary and control function-space moments, obtaining quadratic Wasserstein convergence of the conditioned posterior as padding and frequency cutoff grow. Under the stated spectral regularity, convergence holds in the uniform norm for the response and all derivatives up to the constrained order. It therefore also gives uniform convergence of their posterior means and covariance functions. The result includes Matérn smoothness greater than zero for positivity, greater than one for monotonicity, and greater than two for convexity.

Two applications show why retaining joint uncertainty about the response and its derivatives matters. Under the differential absorption lidar approximation, mercury concentration is proportional to the range derivative of a latent negative log signal ratio, so nonnegative concentration requires that curve to be nondecreasing. For leaf light-response data, concavity instead encodes a nonincreasing marginal gain in assimilation as irradiance increases, without requiring assimilation itself to increase throughout the range. These analyses illustrate how a scientifically specified shape restriction changes derivative inference.

This paper is organized as follows. Section 2 introduces the spectral model and its conditioning events, followed by the Gaussian coefficient construction for positivity, monotonicity, convexity, and their joint combinations in Section 2.1. Section 3 studies posterior geometry, numerical conditioning error, and convergence to the conditioned underlying GP, and Section 4 describes posterior computation. Section 5 presents the mercury lidar and leaf light-response applications, followed by the discussion in Section 6.

All proofs are given in the supplementary material.

Stan implementations of the monotone and convex models, together with R code for reproducing the two applications, are available from the author's GitHub repository.

2 Methods

The Hilbert space Gaussian process (HSGP) construction of Solin and Särkkä (2020) approximates a stationary GP by a finite expansion in Laplacian eigenfunctions with Gaussian coefficients. The domain determines the basis functions, while the covariance kernel determines the coefficient variances. Changing the kernel or its parameters therefore leaves the basis and its derivatives unchanged, allowing their values at observation and prediction locations to be computed once and reused (Riutort-Mayol et al., 2023). For shape-constrained regression, a further advantage is that the response, slope, and curvature are linear functions of the same coefficients. We can therefore express all three restrictions in a common coefficient space and obtain their conditioned laws from the ordinary Gaussian regression posterior.

Let $k(u)$ be a real stationary covariance function with a spectral density, where $u = x - x'$ is the separation between inputs. We write $S_k : \mathbb{R} \to [0, \infty)$ for its nonnegative, even, integrable spectral density and use the Fourier convention

$$k(u) = \frac{1}{2\pi} \int_{\mathbb{R}} e^{\mathrm{i}\omega u} S_k(\omega)\, d\omega, \qquad u \in \mathbb{R}.$$

Here ω is angular frequency, and $S_k(\omega)$ is the spectral density associated with the covariance function k through this Fourier relation, evaluated at frequency ω. The HSGP expansion uses this density to assign variances at a discrete set of frequencies determined by the Laplacian on a bounded interval.

Fix a center $c \in \mathbb{R}$, a half-width $L > 0$, an integer $m \geq 1$, and a compact interval $I = [x_-, x_+]$ of positive length inside $(c - L, c + L)$. On the padded interval $[c - L, c + L]$, the negative Laplacian

with zero boundary values has eigenvalues ω_j^2 and orthonormal eigenfunctions $\phi_{j,L}$. Using the spectral density S_k, these functions define the finite Gaussian expansion

$$\begin{aligned} \phi_{j,L}(x) &= L^{-1/2}\sin(\omega_j(x-c+L)), \quad \omega_j = j\pi/(2L), \\ f_{\boldsymbol{a}}(x) &= a_0 + \sum_{j=1}^{m} a_j \phi_{j,L}(x), \qquad\qquad a_0 \sim N(\mu_0, \sigma_0^2), \quad a_j \sim N(0, S_k(\omega_j)). \end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

The coefficients are independent, with $\sigma_0 > 0$ and $S_k(\omega_j) > 0$ at each retained frequency, so the finite coefficient law is nondegenerate.

Under this prior, the covariance is

$$\operatorname{Cov}(f_{\boldsymbol{a}}(x), f_{\boldsymbol{a}}(x')) = \sigma_0^2 + \sum_{j=1}^{m} S_k(\omega_j)\phi_{j,L}(x)\phi_{j,L}(x').$$

The sum approximates the stationary covariance $k(x-x')$, while σ_0^2 is the contribution of the random intercept. Because the eigenfunctions vanish at the padded endpoints, the finite covariance is generally nonstationary. Defining the basis on an interval larger than I places this artificial boundary outside the region of inference without requiring the response to vanish at the endpoints of I. The intercept permits uncertainty in the overall response level without changing slope or curvature.

For observations $\boldsymbol{y} \in \mathbb{R}^n$ at $x_i \in I$, the Gaussian observation model is

$$\boldsymbol{Y} \mid \boldsymbol{a} \sim N((f_{\boldsymbol{a}}(x_1), \ldots, f_{\boldsymbol{a}}(x_n))^T, \boldsymbol{\Sigma}),$$

where the noise covariance $\boldsymbol{\Sigma}$ is positive definite and the errors are independent of the coefficients. For given covariance and noise parameters and a chosen basis, we study the coefficient posterior conditional on the observed responses and their locations.

Write $\boldsymbol{a} = (a_0, \ldots, a_m)^T$. If $\boldsymbol{X}$ has rows $(1, \phi_{1,L}(x_i), \ldots, \phi_{m,L}(x_i))$, set $\boldsymbol{m}_0 = (\mu_0, 0, \ldots, 0)^T$ and $\boldsymbol{V}_0 = \operatorname{diag}(\sigma_0^2, S_k(\omega_1), \ldots, S_k(\omega_m))$. The coefficients and observations then have the joint Gaussian distribution

$$\begin{pmatrix} \boldsymbol{a} \\ \boldsymbol{Y} \end{pmatrix} \sim N\left(\begin{pmatrix} \boldsymbol{m}_0 \\ \boldsymbol{X}\boldsymbol{m}_0 \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} \boldsymbol{V}_0 & \boldsymbol{V}_0\boldsymbol{X}^T \\ \boldsymbol{X}\boldsymbol{V}_0 & \boldsymbol{X}\boldsymbol{V}_0\boldsymbol{X}^T + \boldsymbol{\Sigma} \end{pmatrix} \right).$$

Here $\boldsymbol{\Sigma}$ is the noise covariance, while $\boldsymbol{X}\boldsymbol{V}_0\boldsymbol{X}^T + \boldsymbol{\Sigma}$ is the marginal covariance of the observations. Conditioning this joint distribution on $\boldsymbol{Y} = \boldsymbol{y}$ gives the ordinary Gaussian posterior

$$\begin{aligned} &\boldsymbol{a} \mid \boldsymbol{y} \sim N(\boldsymbol{m}, \boldsymbol{V}), \\ &\quad \boldsymbol{m} = \boldsymbol{m}_0 + \boldsymbol{V}_0\boldsymbol{X}^T(\boldsymbol{X}\boldsymbol{V}_0\boldsymbol{X}^T + \boldsymbol{\Sigma})^{-1}(\boldsymbol{y} - \boldsymbol{X}\boldsymbol{m}_0), \\ &\quad \boldsymbol{V} = \boldsymbol{V}_0 - \boldsymbol{V}_0\boldsymbol{X}^T(\boldsymbol{X}\boldsymbol{V}_0\boldsymbol{X}^T + \boldsymbol{\Sigma})^{-1}\boldsymbol{X}\boldsymbol{V}_0. \end{aligned} \tag{2}$$

These equations specify the Gaussian law that we will condition on shape, with factorizations and linear solves used in its numerical preparation.

We treat positivity, monotonicity, and convexity as sign restrictions of orders zero, one, and two. Write $C^0(I) = C(I)$ and $\frac{\mathrm{d}^0 f}{\mathrm{d}x^0} = f$. For $r \in \{0, 1, 2\}$ we condition the ordinary posterior on the function-space event

$$\mathcal{C}_r = \left\{ f \in C^r(I) : \min_{x \in I} \frac{\mathrm{d}^r f}{\mathrm{d}x^r}(x) \geq 0 \right\}. \tag{3}$$

The zero order gives a nonnegative response, the first gives nondecreasing regression, and the second gives convex regression, with $\mathcal{C}_r$ also denoting its explicitly identified preimage in coefficient space.

The restriction requires nonnegativity but does not impose a fixed positive lower bound on the response, slope, or curvature.

Shape information can equivalently be incorporated into the prior. Provided that $\mathcal{C}_r$ has positive prior probability, we may restrict the Gaussian prior to curves in $\mathcal{C}_r$ and then update it using the observation likelihood. This gives the same posterior as first performing ordinary Gaussian updating and then conditioning on $\mathcal{C}_r$, because the prior normalizing constant cancels in Bayes' formula.

2.1 Continuum constraints through a Gaussian coefficient

To express a continuum restriction through one coefficient, we first choose a function in the retained span whose selected derivative, including the function itself at order zero, is positive throughout I. A sufficiently large coefficient along this function then makes the selected quantity nonnegative everywhere on the interval, whatever the values of the remaining coefficients. Since an invertible change of coordinates preserves every admissible coefficient vector in the finite space, the restriction can be represented by a single lower bound without changing the underlying Gaussian law. The following result integrates that coefficient and reconstructs it conditionally, using the standard normal distribution function Φ and survival function $\Phi^{\mathrm{c}}(x) = 1 - \Phi(x)$.

Theorem 1 (Gaussian conditioning under a continuum sign restriction)**.** *Under the finite Gaussian model in Section 2, let $\boldsymbol{a} = (a_0, \dots, a_m)^T$ denote the coefficient vector and fix $r \in \{0, 1, 2\}$. Suppose an invertible linear change of coordinates $\boldsymbol{a} \mapsto (\boldsymbol{g}, \gamma) \in \mathbb{R}^m \times \mathbb{R}$ gives $f_{\boldsymbol{a}} = f_{\boldsymbol{g}} + \gamma h_r$. Here h_r is a fixed function in the retained span, chosen to have a uniformly positive rth derivative on I, and γ is its scalar coefficient. The curve $f_{\boldsymbol{g}}$ depends linearly on the remaining coordinates $\boldsymbol{g}$. Assume these functions belong to $C^r(I)$ with $\min_{x \in I} \frac{\mathrm{d}^r h_r}{\mathrm{d}x^r}(x) > 0$. In these coordinates, the ordinary Gaussian posterior has the form*

$$\boldsymbol{g} \mid \boldsymbol{y} \sim N(\boldsymbol{m}_g, \boldsymbol{V}_g), \qquad \gamma \mid \boldsymbol{g}, \boldsymbol{y} \sim N(\mu(\boldsymbol{g}), s^2). \tag{4}$$

Here $\boldsymbol{V}_g$ is positive definite, μ is affine, and $s > 0$ is constant in $\boldsymbol{g}$. The finite, attained threshold

$$\tau_r(\boldsymbol{g}) = \max_{x \in I} \frac{-\frac{\mathrm{d}^r f_{\boldsymbol{g}}}{\mathrm{d}x^r}(x)}{\frac{\mathrm{d}^r h_r}{\mathrm{d}x^r}(x)} \tag{5}$$

satisfies $f_{\boldsymbol{a}} \in \mathcal{C}_r$ exactly when $\gamma \geq \tau_r(\boldsymbol{g})$. This event has positive ordinary posterior probability and a null boundary in coefficient space. Its marginal density for $\boldsymbol{g}$ with respect to Lebesgue measure on $\mathbb{R}^m$ is

$$p(\boldsymbol{g} \mid \boldsymbol{y}, \mathcal{C}_r) = \frac{p(\boldsymbol{g} \mid \boldsymbol{y}) \Phi^{\mathrm{c}}((\tau_r(\boldsymbol{g}) - \mu(\boldsymbol{g}))/s)}{P(f_{\boldsymbol{a}} \in \mathcal{C}_r \mid \boldsymbol{y})}. \tag{6}$$

Given this draw of $\boldsymbol{g}$, draw γ from the conditional normal in Equation (4) truncated below at $\tau_r(\boldsymbol{g})$ and apply the inverse coefficient map. Equivalently, for an independent $U \sim \mathrm{Uniform}(0, 1)$,

$$\gamma = \mu(\boldsymbol{g}) - s\Phi^{-1}\big(U\Phi^{\mathrm{c}}((\tau_r(\boldsymbol{g}) - \mu(\boldsymbol{g}))/s)\big). \tag{7}$$

This reconstructs the full conditioned coefficient law, under which $\min_I \frac{\mathrm{d}^r f_{\boldsymbol{a}}}{\mathrm{d}x^r} > 0$ almost surely.

The Gaussian tail in Equation (6) is the conditional probability that the separated coefficient is large enough to satisfy the constraint, so values of $\boldsymbol{g}$ receive less posterior weight when they require an unlikely value of that coefficient. Conditional reconstruction retains the resulting dependence on $\boldsymbol{g}$ and therefore gives joint draws of the curve and its derivatives. This dependence is inherited from

the original Gaussian model and must be transported through the coefficient map, since assigning a new independent prior to the transformed coordinates would change the law.

A related conditioning structure appears in GP regression with censored observations, where a Gaussian posterior density is weighted by the conditional probability of the censoring event (Gorm Hoffmann et al., 2025). In that setting, inequalities describe censored measurements at finitely many locations, whereas the threshold here represents a restriction on the latent curve throughout an interval.

The null-boundary statement in Theorem 1 means that, under its assumptions, the conditioned law assigns probability zero to curves whose minimum response or selected derivative equals zero. Thus a draw from this law has a strictly positive minimum almost surely, although these minima can be arbitrarily close to zero. For monotonicity, positivity of the derivative at every point is stronger than strict ordering of function values, which alone does not require a positive derivative everywhere. Nearly flat regions therefore remain possible, but the analyticity of the finite expansion means that assigning positive probability to exact plateaus or linear segments of positive length requires a different prior.

The random intercept supplies a constant direction for positivity, whereas monotonicity and convexity require directions with positive slope and curvature. For each choice, evaluating the threshold still requires finding a global extremum over I. On the padded interval of length $2L$, the zero boundary conditions require $\sin(2L\omega_j) = 0$, giving $\omega_j = j\pi/(2L) = j\omega_1$ for $j \geq 1$. The basis and its derivatives therefore involve sine and cosine harmonics of a common fundamental frequency. We introduce

$$\theta(x) = \omega_1(x - c + L), \qquad w(x) = \cos\theta(x),$$

because each cosine harmonic becomes a polynomial in w, while each sine harmonic becomes $\sin\theta$ times a polynomial in w, through identities for the Chebyshev polynomials in Definition 1. These identities allow the stationary locations needed for the thresholds to be characterized by polynomial equations.

Since I lies strictly inside the padded domain, $0 < \theta(x) < \pi$ and $\mathrm{d}w/\mathrm{d}x = -\omega_1 \sin\theta(x) < 0$ throughout I. Thus w maps I one-to-one onto a compact interval in $(-1, 1)$, reversing the order of its endpoints. Its nonzero derivative ensures that interior stationary locations correspond in the two coordinates, so the change of variable preserves the complete search for a continuum extremum.

Definition 1 (Chebyshev polynomials)**.** The Chebyshev polynomials of the first kind, T_j, and second kind, U_j, are defined for $w \in \mathbb{R}$ by the initial values and recurrences

$$\begin{aligned} T_0(w) &= 1, \quad T_1(w) = w, \quad T_{j+1}(w) = 2wT_j(w) - T_{j-1}(w), \\ U_0(w) &= 1, \quad U_1(w) = 2w, \quad U_{j+1}(w) = 2wU_j(w) - U_{j-1}(w), \end{aligned}$$

where the recurrences hold for integers $j \geq 1$.

For $w = \cos\theta$, these polynomials satisfy the standard trigonometric identities (DLMF, Equations (18.5.1) and (18.5.2))

$$T_j(w) = \cos(j\theta), \qquad \sin\theta\, U_{j-1}(w) = \sin(j\theta), \qquad j \geq 1.$$

In particular, the basis and its first two derivatives satisfy

$$\phi_{j,L}(x) = \frac{\sin\theta(x)}{\sqrt{L}}\, U_{j-1}(w(x)), \quad \frac{\mathrm{d}\phi_{j,L}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x) = \frac{j\omega_1}{\sqrt{L}}\, T_j(w(x)), \quad \frac{\mathrm{d}^2\phi_{j,L}}{\mathrm{d}x^2}(x) = -\omega_j^2\phi_{j,L}(x).$$

The second derivative therefore shares the sine factor in the first identity. For positivity, the polynomial representing the first derivative identifies the stationary locations of the curve. With the

directions chosen below, monotonicity gives a ratio of polynomials with a positive denominator, while convexity gives a polynomial after the common sine factor cancels. Differentiating these expressions reduces their stationary-point conditions to polynomial equations. Evaluating the interval endpoints and these locations determines the global thresholds, with constant cases handled explicitly in the corollaries.

The following three corollaries apply Theorem 1 to positivity, monotonicity, and convexity, specifying a suitable direction and the corresponding continuum threshold for each restriction.

Corollary 1 (Positivity in the Laplacian expansion)**.** *Under the finite Gaussian model in Section 2, suppose $m \geq 1$ and $I \subset (c-L, c+L)$. Set $h_0 = 1$, $\boldsymbol{g} = (a_1, \ldots, a_m)^T$, and $f_{\boldsymbol{g}} = \sum_{j=1}^m a_j \phi_{j,L}$. Then $f_{\boldsymbol{a}} = f_{\boldsymbol{g}} + a_0 h_0$, with inverse obtained by reinserting a_0.*

For $\theta(x) = \omega_1(x - c + L)$, $w(x) = \cos\theta(x)$, and $J = [w(x_+), w(x_-)] \subset (-1, 1)$, define $P_{0,\boldsymbol{g}}(w) = \sum_{j=1}^m j a_j T_j(w)$. The threshold is

$$\tau_0(\boldsymbol{g}) = -\min_{x \in I} f_{\boldsymbol{g}}(x). \tag{8}$$

Theorem 1 applies with scalar coefficient $\gamma = a_0$.

The threshold is attained at a physical endpoint or a location whose cosine coordinate is an interior real root in J of $P_{0,\boldsymbol{g}}$. This stationary polynomial has degree at most m when nonzero. All root multiplicities and reduced degrees are included. If the stationary polynomial vanishes identically, the curve $f_{\boldsymbol{g}}$ is constant and either endpoint suffices.

Corollary 2 (Monotonicity in the Laplacian expansion)**.** *Under the finite Gaussian model in Section 2, suppose $m \geq 4$ and $I \subset [c - L/2, c + L/2]$. Set $h_1 = -\phi_{2,L} - \phi_{4,L}/4$, $\boldsymbol{g} = (g_0, g_1, g_3, \ldots, g_m)^T$, and $f_{\boldsymbol{g}} = g_0 + \sum_{j=1}^m g_j \phi_{j,L}$, where $g_2 = 0$, $g_4 = a_4 - a_2/4$, and $g_j = a_j$ for $j \notin \{2, 4\}$. Then $f_{\boldsymbol{a}} = f_{\boldsymbol{g}} + (-a_2) h_1$, with inverse obtained by reinserting a_2 and setting $a_4 = g_4 + a_2/4$.*

For $\theta(x) = \omega_1(x - c + L)$, $w(x) = \cos\theta(x)$, and $J = [w(x_+), w(x_-)] \subset [-1/\sqrt{2}, 1/\sqrt{2}]$, define

$$P_{\boldsymbol{g}}(w) = \sum_{\substack{1 \leq j \leq m \\ j \neq 2}} j g_j T_j(w), \qquad D(w) = 1 + 4w^2 - 8w^4. \tag{9}$$

Since $D \geq 1$ on J, the threshold is

$$\tau_1(\boldsymbol{g}) = \max_{w \in J} \frac{-P_{\boldsymbol{g}}(w)}{D(w)}. \tag{10}$$

Theorem 1 applies with scalar coefficient $\gamma = -a_2$.

The threshold is attained at a physical endpoint or a location whose cosine coordinate is an interior real root in J of $\frac{\mathrm{d}P_{\boldsymbol{g}}}{\mathrm{d}w} D - P_{\boldsymbol{g}} \frac{\mathrm{d}D}{\mathrm{d}w}$. This stationary polynomial has degree at most $m + 3$ when nonzero. All root multiplicities and reduced degrees are included. If the stationary polynomial vanishes identically, the quotient $-P_{\boldsymbol{g}}/D$ is constant and either endpoint suffices. A nonzero constant stationary polynomial gives only endpoint candidates.

Corollary 3 (Convexity in the Laplacian expansion)**.** *Under the finite Gaussian model in Section 2, suppose $m \geq 2$ and $I \subset (c - L, c + L)$. Set $h_2 = -\phi_{1,L}$, $\boldsymbol{g} = (a_0, a_2, \ldots, a_m)^T$, and $f_{\boldsymbol{g}} = a_0 + \sum_{j=2}^m a_j \phi_{j,L}$. Then $f_{\boldsymbol{a}} = f_{\boldsymbol{g}} + (-a_1) h_2$, with inverse obtained by reinserting a_1.*

For $\theta(x) = \omega_1(x - c + L)$, $w(x) = \cos\theta(x)$, and $J = [w(x_+), w(x_-)] \subset (-1, 1)$, define the polynomial and threshold

$$Q_{\boldsymbol{g}}(w) = \sum_{j=2}^m j^2 a_j U_{j-1}(w), \qquad \tau_2(\boldsymbol{g}) = \max_{w \in J} Q_{\boldsymbol{g}}(w). \tag{11}$$

Theorem 1 applies with scalar coefficient $\gamma = -a_1$.

The threshold is attained at a physical endpoint or a location whose cosine coordinate is an interior real root in J *of* $\frac{\mathrm{d}Q_{\boldsymbol{g}}}{\mathrm{d}w}$. *The polynomial* $Q_{\boldsymbol{g}}$ *has degree at most* $m-1$, *so its stationary polynomial has degree at most* $m-2$ *when nonzero. All root multiplicities and reduced degrees are included. If the stationary polynomial vanishes identically,* $Q_{\boldsymbol{g}}$ *is constant and either endpoint suffices. A nonzero constant stationary polynomial gives only endpoint candidates.*

For positivity, separating a_0 leaves the spectral curve $f_{\boldsymbol{g}}$, and Equation (8) is the vertical shift needed to make its minimum nonnegative. The intercept's conditional posterior mean can depend on the spectral coefficients, so reconstruction uses that conditional law even though the prior coordinates are independent. The monotonicity map makes the same need to preserve dependence explicit by replacing a_4 with $g_4 = a_4 - a_2/4$, which is correlated with the separated coefficient $-a_2$. The convexity map simply sets aside the first mode, but all three constructions transport the ordinary Gaussian posterior before conditioning. In the two derivative cases, the intercept stays among the remaining coefficients and can change its posterior through correlation, despite contributing neither slope nor curvature.

Although all three constructions use the same padded basis domain $(c-L, c+L)$, their directions give different sufficient conditions on the physical interval. The constant positivity direction requires no additional padding, and h_2 has positive curvature throughout the open basis domain, whereas the slope of the chosen h_1 is bounded away from zero on the central half, including its endpoints. The conditions in Table 2 reflect these properties of the selected directions, so imposing the central-half condition on convexity would unnecessarily restrict that finite result.

Quantity	Positivity	Monotonicity	Convexity
Selected order	$r = 0$	$r = 1$	$r = 2$
Separated coefficient	a_0	$-a_2$	$-a_1$
Direction	1	$-\phi_{2,L} - \phi_{4,L}/4$	$-\phi_{1,L}$
Finite interval	$I \subset (c-L, c+L)$	$I \subset [c-L/2, c+L/2]$	$I \subset (c-L, c+L)$
Rank condition	$m \geq 1$	$m \geq 4$	$m \geq 2$
Threshold	$-\min_I f_{\boldsymbol{g}}$	$\max_J(-P_{\boldsymbol{g}}/D)$	$\max_J Q_{\boldsymbol{g}}$
Polynomial degree bound	m	$m+3$	$m-2$
Limit space	$C(I)$	$C^1(I)$	$C^2(I)$
Matérn smoothness	$\nu > 0$	$\nu > 1$	$\nu > 2$

Table 2: Positivity, monotonicity, and convexity as alternative conditioning events in the same spectral model. Here I is the physical interval and J its image under the decreasing cosine coordinate w. The degree bounds apply to the nonzero polynomials whose roots identify stationary locations. The finite rank and interval conditions are sufficient for the displayed directions. The function-space limits additionally require Assumption 2 and the padding and frequency-cutoff limits in Theorem 2.

To compute the thresholds in Equations (8), (10) and (11), we compare values at the two interval endpoints and at the interior stationary locations identified by the polynomial roots in J. For positivity, we evaluate $f_{\boldsymbol{g}}$ at the corresponding locations in I and take the negative of the smallest value. For monotonicity and convexity, we take the largest value of $-P_{\boldsymbol{g}}/D$ and $Q_{\boldsymbol{g}}$, respectively, at the candidate values of w. Every interior real root must be included, even when the derivative does not change sign there. If the stationary polynomial vanishes identically, the function being optimized is constant and an endpoint evaluation suffices.

Nonpositivity, nonincreasing regression, and concavity follow by negating the observations and prior mean while retaining all covariances, then applying the corresponding nonnegative-derivative construction and negating the reconstructed curve and its derivatives. In particular, concavity makes the slope nonincreasing but allows it to have either sign, so a curvature restriction alone does not impose monotonicity. Table 3 summarizes the inverse maps for all six individual sign constraints.

Constraint	Reinserted coefficients	Remaining coefficients
Positivity	$a_0 = \gamma$	$a_j = g_j$, $1 \le j \le m$
Negativity	$a_0 = -\gamma$	$a_j = -g_j$, $1 \le j \le m$
Nondecreasing	$a_2 = -\gamma$, $a_4 = g_4 - \gamma/4$	$a_j = g_j$, $j \notin \{2, 4\}$
Nonincreasing	$a_2 = \gamma$, $a_4 = -g_4 + \gamma/4$	$a_j = -g_j$, $j \notin \{2, 4\}$
Convexity	$a_1 = -\gamma$	$a_j = g_j$, $j \neq 1$
Concavity	$a_1 = \gamma$	$a_j = -g_j$, $j \neq 1$

Table 3: Inverse maps to the original coefficients for six constraints on I. Positivity and negativity mean $f_{\boldsymbol{a}} \ge 0$ and $f_{\boldsymbol{a}} \le 0$. The negative, nonincreasing, and concave cases use $(\boldsymbol{g}, \gamma)$ from the Gaussian calculation for $-f_{\boldsymbol{a}}$ with negated observations and prior mean. The other cases use $f_{\boldsymbol{a}}$. Indices range from 0 to m unless stated otherwise, and g_j retains its original coefficient index. Each pair uses the rank and padding conditions of its corresponding case in Corollaries 1 to 3.

Several restrictions can describe different aspects of the same response. A nonnegative, nondecreasing, concave curve, for example, has a nonnegative level and slope, with the slope nonincreasing across the interval. We express such intersections by selecting derivative orders and a sign at each order. For a nonempty index set $A \subseteq \{0, 1, 2\}$ and a sign choice $\varepsilon : A \to \{-1, 1\}$, write $\varepsilon_r = \varepsilon(r)$ and define

$$\mathcal{C}_A^{\varepsilon} = \left\{ f \in C^{\max A}(I) : \varepsilon_r \frac{\mathrm{d}^r f}{\mathrm{d}x^r}(x) \ge 0 \text{ for every } r \in A \text{ and } x \in I \right\}. \tag{12}$$

At order zero, the two signs give nonnegativity and nonpositivity. At orders one and two, they give nondecreasingness and nonincreasingness, and convexity and concavity, respectively. Taking $\varepsilon_r = 1$ at every selected order gives positivity, nondecreasingness, and convexity, their three pairwise combinations, and their triple combination. Allowing either sign gives six individual cases and 20 joint combinations without opposing signs. Imposing both signs at the same order instead forces the corresponding derivative to vanish throughout I, an event of zero probability under the finite Gaussian model.

To retain the scalar conditioning construction, we need one direction h in the retained span whose selected signed derivatives are all uniformly positive on I. Increasing its coefficient then increases every signed derivative involved in the restriction. Each order and location imposes a lower bound on this same coefficient, so their largest bound enforces the entire intersection. The direction condition must be verified for the chosen combination, rank, and interval. The following proposition gives the resulting Gaussian conditioning law.

Proposition 1 (Joint sign constraints)**.** *Under the finite Gaussian model in Section 2, let* $\boldsymbol{a} = (a_0, \ldots, a_m)^T$ *denote the coefficient vector and fix a nonempty* $A \subseteq \{0, 1, 2\}$ *and signs* $\varepsilon : A \to \{-1, 1\}$*, with event* $\mathcal{C}_A^{\varepsilon}$ *defined in Equation (12). Suppose an invertible linear change of coordinates* $\boldsymbol{a} \mapsto (\boldsymbol{g}, \gamma) \in \mathbb{R}^m \times \mathbb{R}$ *gives* $f_{\boldsymbol{a}} = f_{\boldsymbol{g}} + \gamma h$*. Here* h *is a fixed function in the retained span, shared by*

all selected orders, γ is its scalar coefficient, and $f_{\boldsymbol{g}}$ depends linearly on the remaining coordinates $\boldsymbol{g}$. Assume $h, f_{\boldsymbol{g}} \in C^{\max A}(I)$ with $\min_{x\in I} \varepsilon_r \frac{\mathrm{d}^r h}{\mathrm{d}x^r}(x) > 0$ for every $r \in A$. Define

$$\eta_r(x;\boldsymbol{g}) = \frac{-\varepsilon_r \frac{\mathrm{d}^r f_{\boldsymbol{g}}}{\mathrm{d}x^r}(x)}{\varepsilon_r \frac{\mathrm{d}^r h}{\mathrm{d}x^r}(x)}, \qquad \tau_A^{\varepsilon}(\boldsymbol{g}) = \max_{r\in A} \max_{x\in I} \eta_r(x;\boldsymbol{g}). \tag{13}$$

This finite, attained threshold satisfies $f_{\boldsymbol{a}} \in \mathcal{C}_A^{\varepsilon}$ exactly when $\gamma \geq \tau_A^{\varepsilon}(\boldsymbol{g})$. The event has positive ordinary posterior probability and a null coefficient boundary. Its marginal density and reconstruction are Equations (6) and (7), with $\tau_r, \mathcal{C}_r$ replaced by $\tau_A^{\varepsilon}, \mathcal{C}_A^{\varepsilon}$ and the Gaussian parameters in Equation (4) computed under this map. The conditioned law satisfies $\min_{x\in I} \varepsilon_r \frac{\mathrm{d}^r f_{\boldsymbol{a}}}{\mathrm{d}x^r}(x) > 0$ almost surely for every $r \in A$. The envelope, strong log-concavity, and conservative threshold-error conclusions extend under their respective hypotheses.

The joint restrictions can also reduce the number of continuum searches. For the nonnegative, nondecreasing, concave example, take $A = \{0, 1, 2\}$ with $\varepsilon_0 = \varepsilon_1 = 1$ and $\varepsilon_2 = -1$. Concavity makes the slope smallest at x_+, and nondecreasingness makes the response smallest at x_-. Under the common map in Proposition 1, the threshold therefore becomes

$$\tau_A^{\varepsilon}(\boldsymbol{g}) = \max\left\{\max_{x\in I} \eta_2(x;\boldsymbol{g}), \eta_1(x_+;\boldsymbol{g}), \eta_0(x_-;\boldsymbol{g})\right\}.$$

Thus this combination requires one continuum curvature bound and two endpoint bounds. All three use the same h and $\boldsymbol{g}$, whose choice determines the quotients in Equation (13). The supplementary material gives the HSGP coefficient map, conditions on its direction coefficients, and the reductions for all sign choices, with a table separating continuum and endpoint bounds for the 20 joint cases.

3 Geometry, numerical error, and approximation

At a fixed location $x \in I$, the ratio in Equation (5) is the lower bound on γ required to satisfy the sign restriction at that location. Because $f_{\boldsymbol{g}}$ depends linearly on $\boldsymbol{g}$ and h_r is fixed, this bound is a linear function $\boldsymbol{\beta}_r(x)^T\boldsymbol{g}$. Here $\boldsymbol{\beta}_r(x) \in \mathbb{R}^m$ is the vector of coefficient multipliers, with its entries ordered as those of $\boldsymbol{g}$. For positivity, for example, $h_0 = 1$ and $\boldsymbol{g} = (a_1, \ldots, a_m)^T$, so $\boldsymbol{\beta}_0(x) = (-\phi_{1,L}(x), \ldots, -\phi_{m,L}(x))^T$. The continuum threshold is therefore

$$\tau_r(\boldsymbol{g}) = \max_{x\in I} \boldsymbol{\beta}_r(x)^T\boldsymbol{g}.$$

The continuity assumptions and positive derivative bound in Theorem 1 make $\boldsymbol{\beta}_r$ continuous and bounded on I, so the maximum representation makes τ_r convex, positively homogeneous, and globally Lipschitz. The threshold enters the log posterior through the normal survival weight, so its derivatives are needed to compute the gradients used in posterior sampling. Danskin's theorem (Danskin, 1966) expresses these derivatives through the coefficient vectors at maximizing locations. When the maximizing location $x_\star$ is unique, the threshold has gradient $\boldsymbol{\beta}_r(x_\star)$. Several maximizing locations also permit a gradient when their coefficient vectors agree, whereas different vectors produce kinks. The supplementary material gives the threshold derivatives and the resulting log-posterior gradient formulas. For a joint restriction in Proposition 1, the vectors are formed under the common coefficient map and the maximum ranges over pairs $(r, x) \in A \times I$. A change in the maximizing derivative order can therefore produce a kink as well as a change in its location.

Let $\boldsymbol{B}\boldsymbol{B}^T = \boldsymbol{V}_g$ with $\boldsymbol{B}$ invertible, and write $\boldsymbol{g}(\boldsymbol{z}) = \boldsymbol{m}_g + \boldsymbol{B}\boldsymbol{z}$. The exact whitened log density, up to a constant, is

$$-\tfrac{1}{2}\|\boldsymbol{z}\|^2 + \log \Phi^{\mathrm{c}}\left(\frac{\tau_r(\boldsymbol{g}(\boldsymbol{z})) - \mu(\boldsymbol{g}(\boldsymbol{z}))}{s}\right). \tag{14}$$

The supplementary material establishes that this density is 1-strongly log-concave, giving a unique mode and finite moments of every polynomial order.

The continuum maximum generally requires numerical evaluation, and an underestimated threshold would admit curves that violate the intended sign restriction. We therefore use a conservative upper threshold $\widetilde{\tau}_r \geq \tau_r$, so that imposing $\gamma \geq \widetilde{\tau}_r(\boldsymbol{g})$ preserves the restriction. The cost is that admissible coefficient values between the exact and upper thresholds are excluded from the posterior. The upper threshold may not be convex, so the log-concavity conclusion need not carry over to this numerical posterior. Its difference from the exact law can instead be quantified through the probability mass of the excluded coefficients, as the following proposition shows under exact Gaussian operations.

Proposition 2 (Posterior error from a conservative continuum threshold)**.** *Under Theorem 1, let $\widetilde{\tau}_r$ be measurable and satisfy $\tau_r \leq \widetilde{\tau}_r \leq \tau_r + \delta$ almost everywhere under the ordinary posterior of $\boldsymbol{g}$, for a fixed $\delta \geq 0$. Use the same upper threshold in marginal weighting and reconstruction. Let $P_{\boldsymbol{y}}$ be the ordinary coefficient posterior, and use $\mathcal{C}_r$ also for its coefficient preimage. Define $\widetilde{\mathcal{C}}_r = \{\gamma \geq \widetilde{\tau}_r(\boldsymbol{g})\}$. Both conditioned laws exist and, with* $\mathrm{TV}(P, Q) = \sup_A |P(A) - Q(A)|$,

$$\mathrm{TV}(P_{\boldsymbol{y}}(\cdot \mid \widetilde{\mathcal{C}}_r), P_{\boldsymbol{y}}(\cdot \mid \mathcal{C}_r)) = 1 - \frac{P_{\boldsymbol{y}}(\widetilde{\mathcal{C}}_r)}{P_{\boldsymbol{y}}(\mathcal{C}_r)} \leq \min\left(1, \frac{\delta}{s\sqrt{2\pi} P_{\boldsymbol{y}}(\mathcal{C}_r)}\right). \tag{15}$$

Every measurable summary of the reconstructed coefficients inherits this bound. The identity holds for any inner event of positive probability.

The conditioning probability in Equation (15) explains why a rare shape event is more sensitive to a given absolute threshold error. The bound requires the threshold guarantee to hold globally or almost everywhere under the ordinary posterior and quantifies the effect of threshold arithmetic within the finite model, leaving basis approximation and finite-chain error as separate quantities.

3.1 Convergence to the conditioned underlying GP

We next consider the error introduced by replacing the underlying GP with a finite HSGP expansion, and how this error depends on padding and rank. Increasing L separates the artificial boundary from the physical interval I, whereas m/L controls the frequency cutoff, so increasing padding at fixed rank can remove variation at short scales. The two choices must therefore be considered together and for the derivative used in inference as well as for the response (Riutort-Mayol et al., 2023).

Because the conditioning event depends on the response or its selected derivative between grid points, convergence of covariance blocks on a finite grid is insufficient for comparing the conditioned laws. We instead work on the entire physical interval in $C^r(I)$ with its Borel sigma-field and norm

$$\|f\|_{C^r} = \sum_{j=0}^{r} \sup_{x \in I} \left| \frac{\mathrm{d}^j f}{\mathrm{d}x^j}(x) \right|, \qquad \frac{\mathrm{d}^0 f}{\mathrm{d}x^0} = f.$$

Assumption 1 (Common underlying and finite Gaussian models)**.** Fix $I \subset [c - R, c + R]$ with $R > 0$ and the observation model and intercept law specified in Section 2. Let $F = a_0 + W$, where W is a centered stationary GP on $\mathbb{R}$, independent of a_0, with covariance function k and spectral density S_k as defined in Section 2. Use that same spectrum and intercept in the finite models in Equation (1), varying only m and L while keeping the center, interval, spectrum, intercept law, observation locations, positive-definite noise covariance, and data identical in all models.

Assumption 2 (Spectral regularity for the selected order)**.** Fix $r \in \{0, 1, 2\}$. The spectrum S_k is continuous, even, and strictly positive. There is a regularity parameter $\zeta \in (0, 1]$ such that the two functions

$$\omega \longmapsto S_k(\omega), \qquad \omega \longmapsto \omega^{2r+2\zeta} S_k(\omega)$$

are locally absolutely continuous on $[0, \infty)$, and each function and its derivative belongs to $L^1(0, \infty)$. The weighted spectrum $\omega^{2r+2\zeta} S_k(\omega)$ tends to zero as $\omega \downarrow 0$, and we use this limiting value at the origin. The frequency exponent is 2ζ for positivity, $2 + 2\zeta$ for monotonicity, and $4 + 2\zeta$ for convexity.

Under the Fourier representation of the stationary covariance, differentiating r times with respect to each input multiplies the spectrum by ω^{2r}. The additional factor $\omega^{2\zeta}$ allows us to bound the variance of the difference between the rth derivative values at x and x' by a constant multiple of $|x - x'|^{2\zeta}$. With ζ held fixed in the approximation limit, this increment bound supplies the additional regularity needed for continuity and tightness in $C^r(I)$.

Let $\Pi^{\mathcal{C}_r}_{m,L,\boldsymbol{y}}$ and $\Pi^{\mathcal{C}_r}_{\boldsymbol{y}}$ denote the finite and underlying posterior laws obtained by weighting their priors by the common Gaussian likelihood and the indicator of Equation (3). For laws with finite second norm moments, define

$$W_2(P, Q) = \inf_{\lambda} \left(\int \|f - g\|^2_{C^r} \, \lambda(df, dg) \right)^{1/2},$$

where λ ranges over couplings with marginals P, Q.

Convergence in W_2 means that the finite-model curve $F_{m,L}$ and the underlying curve F, with their respective posterior distributions conditional on the data and $\mathcal{C}_r$, can be coupled so that

$$\mathrm{E}\left[\sup_{x \in I} \left| \frac{\mathrm{d}^j F_{m,L}}{\mathrm{d}x^j}(x) - \frac{\mathrm{d}^j F}{\mathrm{d}x^j}(x) \right|^2 \right] \longrightarrow 0, \qquad j = 0, \ldots, r,$$

as $L \to \infty$ and $m/L \to \infty$. Under this coupling, the expected squared maximum discrepancy over I vanishes for the response and each derivative through order r.

Theorem 2 (Convergence of shape-constrained HSGP posteriors)**.** *Fix $r \in \{0, 1, 2\}$ under Assumptions 1 and 2, and consider finite models with $L \geq 2R$ and $m \geq 1$ for $r = 0$, $m \geq 4$ for $r = 1$, or $m \geq 2$ for $r = 2$. The underlying GP has a $C^r(I)$ version, and the finite and underlying shape events have positive probability and null boundaries in that space. Consequently, the posteriors conditional on the data and $\mathcal{C}_r$ exist, with finite moments of every polynomial order in $\|\cdot\|_{C^r}$. As $L \to \infty$ and $m/L \to \infty$,*

$$W_2(\Pi^{\mathcal{C}_r}_{m,L,\boldsymbol{y}}, \Pi^{\mathcal{C}_r}_{\boldsymbol{y}}) \longrightarrow 0. \tag{16}$$

This convergence also holds for the posterior summaries: means of $\frac{\mathrm{d}^j f}{\mathrm{d}x^j}$ converge uniformly on I for every $0 \leq j \leq r$, and covariances between $\frac{\mathrm{d}^{r_1} f}{\mathrm{d}x^{r_1}}(x)$ and $\frac{\mathrm{d}^{r_2} f}{\mathrm{d}x^{r_2}}(x')$ converge uniformly on $I \times I$ for every $0 \leq r_1, r_2 \leq r$. Under the conditioned underlying law, $\min_I \frac{\mathrm{d}^r f}{\mathrm{d}x^r} > 0$ almost surely.

The spectral weight controls the highest derivative in the function-space norm, so positivity needs only a continuous process, whereas monotonicity and convexity require C^1 and C^2 regularity, respectively. The proof adapts the derivative-covariance argument of Jensen and Hoffmann (2026, Theorem 2 and its proof) to the weighted-spectral conditions above, then uses increment moments to obtain convergence in that space and passes through likelihood and event conditioning. This last step requires positive event probability and a null boundary, which the independent random

intercept supplies for positivity and a positive reproducing kernel Hilbert space (RKHS) derivative direction supplies for the two derivative constraints.

Squared exponential spectra satisfy all three sets of conditions. A Matérn spectrum is proportional to $(\lambda^2+\omega^2)^{-(\nu+1/2)}$ with $\lambda>0$ (Rasmussen and Williams, 2006, Chapter 4). Its weight of order d is integrable when $d<2\nu$, and the weighted derivative is integrable for the orders used here, so any $0<\zeta<\min(1,\nu-r)$ verifies Assumption 2 when $\nu>r$. The conditions also hold for positive finite mixtures with a common smaller exponent. A squared exponential covariance multiplied by $\cos(\omega_0 u)$, with fixed $\omega_0\geq 0$, also qualifies because its spectrum is a positive sum of translated Gaussian densities.

4 Posterior computation

Integrating out γ gives a posterior density for the remaining coefficients $\boldsymbol{g}$. We sample from this density and then draw γ from its conditional truncated normal distribution to recover the full coefficient vector. We first form the ordinary Gaussian posterior in Equation (2) and apply the appropriate invertible map from Corollaries 1 to 3, or the common map in Proposition 1, to its mean and covariance, giving the Gaussian laws

$$\boldsymbol{g}\mid\boldsymbol{y}\sim N(\boldsymbol{m}_g,\boldsymbol{V}_g),\qquad \gamma\mid\boldsymbol{g},\boldsymbol{y}\sim N(\mu(\boldsymbol{g}),s^2),$$

where μ is affine and $s>0$ is constant in $\boldsymbol{g}$. These Gaussian parameters can therefore be prepared before marginal sampling, together with an invertible factor $\boldsymbol{B}\boldsymbol{B}^T=\boldsymbol{V}_g$ defining the whitened coordinates $\boldsymbol{g}=\boldsymbol{m}_g+\boldsymbol{B}\boldsymbol{z}$, in which $\boldsymbol{z}$ has the standard normal law on $\mathbb{R}^m$ under the ordinary posterior. Mapping through $\boldsymbol{B}$ preserves the Gaussian dependence among the remaining coefficients.

At each proposed $\boldsymbol{z}$, evaluating the marginal density requires forming $\boldsymbol{g}$ and its continuum threshold $\tau_r(\boldsymbol{g})$. For the individual cases, this means comparing both endpoints and all interior stationary candidates from Corollaries 1 to 3, or obtaining bounds over the entire interval. The Gaussian log-survival term in Equation (14) then weights the standard normal density by the conditional probability that γ satisfies the sign restriction. Since the observation likelihood is already included in the ordinary posterior and the overall conditioning probability is constant in $\boldsymbol{z}$, neither requires a separate evaluation during marginal sampling. The monotonicity and convexity implementations sample this unrestricted m-dimensional density by Hamiltonian Monte Carlo, with the numerical threshold evaluation described below.

For each retained $\boldsymbol{g}$, we recover the separated coefficient by drawing γ from $N(\mu(\boldsymbol{g}),s^2)$ truncated to $[\tau_r(\boldsymbol{g}),\infty)$, using an independent $U\sim\text{Uniform}(0,1)$ and the inverse-survival formula in Equation (7), which retains its conditional uncertainty. Applying the corresponding inverse map in Table 3 then recovers the original coefficients of $f_{\boldsymbol{a}}$. With the exact threshold and draws from the exact marginal law, these two stages recover the full conditioned coefficient law, so evaluating the expansion and its derivatives gives joint posterior curves from which to compute means and pointwise credible intervals.

For a signed joint restriction satisfying Proposition 1, the common map determines both the Gaussian preparation and every quotient $\eta_r(x;\boldsymbol{g})$. At each proposed $\boldsymbol{g}$, we evaluate the required continuum and endpoint bounds and take their maximum to obtain $\tau_A^{\varepsilon}(\boldsymbol{g})$. Since these bounds all concern the same γ, a single survival probability $\Phi^{\mathrm{c}}((\tau_A^{\varepsilon}(\boldsymbol{g})-\mu(\boldsymbol{g}))/s)$ weights the marginal density for the entire intersection. Reconstruction uses this joint lower bound in the truncated normal and then inverts the common coefficient map. The Gaussian parameters must be computed under that map, and the individual thresholds in Table 2, which use different maps, cannot be combined

directly. The supplementary material specifies the HSGP map and the continuum and endpoint bounds for each joint combination.

In numerical evaluation, a successful threshold calculation returns an enclosure whose upper endpoint $\widetilde{\tau}_r$ satisfies

$$\tau_r(\boldsymbol{g}) \le \widetilde{\tau}_r(\boldsymbol{g}) \le \tau_r(\boldsymbol{g}) + \delta$$

for the supplied coefficients and a chosen tolerance $\delta > 0$. If marginal weighting and conditional reconstruction use the same numerical threshold and the enclosure bound holds almost everywhere under the ordinary posterior, Proposition 2 controls the total variation distance between the resulting target distribution and the posterior conditioned on the exact sign event. The conditional standard deviation s provides a natural scale for choosing δ, because δ/s bounds the error in the standardized truncation point. For a prescribed total variation error $\rho \in (0, 1)$, Proposition 2 gives the sufficient choice

$$\delta \le \rho\, s\sqrt{2\pi}\, P_{\boldsymbol{y}}(\mathcal{C}_r).$$

In practice, a valid positive lower bound on the conditioning probability can replace $P_{\boldsymbol{y}}(\mathcal{C}_r)$ on the right-hand side. Without such a bound, a small value of δ/s controls the standardized threshold error but does not by itself certify a small posterior error, particularly when the shape event is rare.

Stable evaluation uses log-survival and inverse-survival calculations to avoid subtracting nearly equal probabilities in the tails. For gradient-based sampling, the derivative implementations evaluate approximate envelope gradients at numerically selected maximizing locations. At a unique maximum these gradients approximate derivatives of the exact threshold, while the sampled log values use the rounded upper threshold. The supplementary material explains how the numerical values and approximate gradients enter the Stan No-U-Turn sampler (NUTS), alongside the compact algorithm, Gaussian block formulas, threshold enclosures, precision controls, and stable reconstruction.

5 Applications

We compare ordinary Gaussian and shape-constrained posteriors in two applications where derivatives have direct scientific interpretations. Monotonicity ensures nonnegative mercury concentration in a lidar model, while concavity represents a nonincreasing marginal gain in leaf carbon assimilation.

5.1 Atmospheric mercury concentration

To illustrate how monotonicity changes derivative inference, we use all 221 released mercury lidar observations over 390–720 meters near the Bella Vista geothermal power station in Italy, distributed with the R package SemiPar (Holst et al., 1996; Feng et al., 2022). Each response is the log ratio of reflected on-resonant and off-resonant laser signals, with approximately 100 pulse pairs averaged during acquisition. These data have also been analyzed with a globally monotone GP approximation by Maatouk et al. (2025a).

The shape restriction follows from the differential absorption lidar (DIAL) approximation, which neglects differential backscatter and attenuation from other species. Under this approximation, the derivative of the mean log ratio per meter equals mercury concentration multiplied by -1.6×10^{-5} square meters per nanogram. Nonnegative concentration therefore requires a nondecreasing latent mean for the negative log ratio, even if the noisy observations are not ordered.

Write r for distance in meters, set $x(r) = (r - 390)/330$, and let Y_i be the negative recorded log ratio. We use 128 basis functions with center $c = 1/2$ and half-width $L = 2$, so the computational

interval $[-1.5, 2.5]$ contains the physical interval $[0, 1]$. The Matérn 7/2 spectral prior in Equation (1) gives the hierarchy

$$f_{\boldsymbol{a}}(x) = a_0 + \sum_{j=1}^{128} a_j \phi_{j,2}(x), \qquad a_0 \sim N(\mu_0, \sigma_0^2),$$
$$a_j \overset{\text{ind}}{\sim} N\left(0, \sigma_f^2 \frac{32\lambda^7}{5(\lambda^2 + \omega_j^2)^4}\right), \qquad \lambda = \frac{\sqrt{7}}{\ell},$$
$$Y_i \mid \boldsymbol{a} \overset{\text{ind}}{\sim} N(f_{\boldsymbol{a}}(x(r_i)), \sigma_i^2).$$

The intercept is independent of the other coefficients, with prior mean $\mu_0 = 0.291156$ and standard deviation $\sigma_0 = 1.952921$. These values are the observed response mean and twice its range, respectively. The underlying GP has marginal standard deviation $\sigma_f = 0.308590$ and normalized length scale $\ell = 0.288869$, corresponding to 95.33 meters.

Following the noise family of Holst et al. (1996), we allow measurement variance to change with distance by setting

$$\sigma_i = \sigma_{\text{mid}} \exp\big(\gamma_1(x(r_i) - c) + \gamma_2(x(r_i) - c)^2\big).$$

Here $\sigma_{\text{mid}} = 0.056125$ is the noise standard deviation at the midpoint of 555 meters, while $\gamma_1 = 2.330252$ and $\gamma_2 = -0.305387$ describe the linear and quadratic changes in its logarithm. All standard deviations are on the negative-logratio scale. We estimate the covariance and noise parameters jointly by ordinary underlying-GP marginal likelihood and use the same estimates in both posterior fits.

The inferential targets are the latent negative log ratio $f_{\boldsymbol{a}}(x(r))$ and the implied concentration

$$\frac{1}{330(1.6 \times 10^{-5})} \left.\frac{\mathrm{d}f_{\boldsymbol{a}}}{\mathrm{d}x}\right|_{x=x(r)} \quad \text{nanograms per cubic meter.}$$

The factor 330 converts the derivative in normalized coordinates to a derivative per meter, so conditioning on $\frac{\mathrm{d}f_{\boldsymbol{a}}}{\mathrm{d}x}(x) \geq 0$ throughout $[0, 1]$ imposes nonnegative concentration over the observed range. We use the procedure in Section 4 for the monotone posterior and evaluate the unconstrained Gaussian summaries analytically. Sampler settings, convergence diagnostics, and the full posterior predictive assessment are given in the supplementary material.

Figure 1 compares concentration inference with and without monotonicity under the same Gaussian model. At 502.86 meters, the ordinary posterior mean concentration reaches its minimum on the reconstruction grid at -42.13 nanograms per cubic meter, with pointwise 95% equal-tail credible interval $(-94.27, 10.00)$ and posterior probability 0.9434 of a negative concentration. Conditioning on monotonicity gives a mean concentration of 11.75 nanograms per cubic meter at that distance, with corresponding interval $(1.10, 31.23)$, while changing the response fit little.

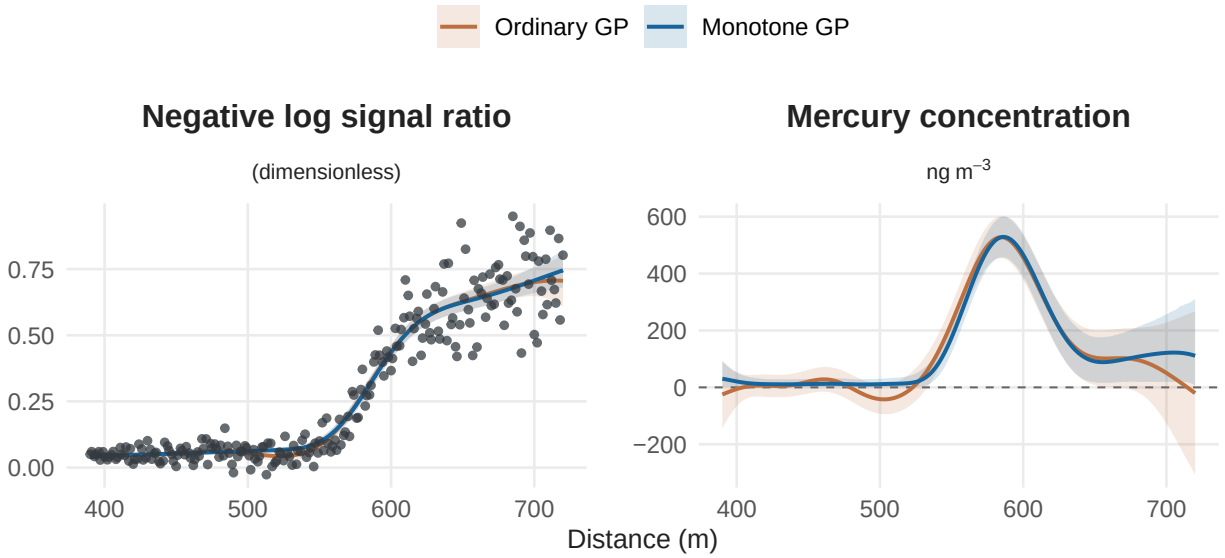


Figure 1: The left panel shows the latent negative log signal ratio with all 221 observations as points, and the right shows mercury concentration in nanograms per cubic meter, given under the DIAL approximation by the range derivative of the latent negative log ratio divided by 1.6×10^{-5} square meters per nanogram. Orange and blue lines denote ordinary and globally monotone posterior means, with shading for pointwise 95% equal-tail latent credible intervals excluding new measurement error. Both fits use the same rank-128 Matérn 7/2 Gaussian regression model and range-dependent noise variances, with the monotone posterior imposing the restriction throughout 390–720 meters.

5.2 Marginal carbon assimilation in a leaf light response

Concavity of a leaf light-response curve means that the marginal gain in carbon assimilation is nonincreasing with irradiance. We examine what this assumption contributes to inference from one response sequence in the Arctic gas-exchange study of Rogers et al. (2019b), using the measurements released by Rogers et al. (2019a). Each record is a chamber measurement of net assimilation on the same leaf at a specified incident irradiance. Before fitting either model, we select the smallest sample identifier in the release, which corresponds to an Eriophorum angustifolium leaf. The study's quality filters and exclusion of the dark measurement leave 13 records over irradiance 19.1–2,000.2 μmol quanta $\mathrm{m}^{-2}\mathrm{s}^{-1}$. The measurements were taken in descending illumination over approximately 37 minutes, with retained leaf temperatures between 14.1 and 15.0 °C.

Let $A(q)$ denote mean net assimilation at irradiance q under the chamber conditions, measured in μmol CO_2 $\mathrm{m}^{-2}\mathrm{s}^{-1}$. We compare the ordinary Gaussian posterior with its restriction to $\frac{\mathrm{d}^2 A}{\mathrm{d}q^2}(q) \le 0$ over the observed irradiance range. In the scaled coordinate $x = (q - q_0)/d$, q_0 is the midpoint of that range and d its half-width, so the physical interval becomes $[-1, 1]$. The shared model is

$$\begin{aligned} A(q) &= a_0 + \sum_{j=1}^{24} a_j \phi_{j,2}((q - q_0)/d), \qquad a_0 \sim N(0, 20^2), \\ a_j &\overset{\text{ind}}{\sim} N\left(0, \sigma_f^2 \sqrt{2\pi}\ell \exp(-\ell^2 \omega_j^2/2)\right), \\ y_i \mid A &\overset{\text{ind}}{\sim} N(A(q_i), \sigma_\varepsilon^2). \end{aligned} \tag{17}$$

The intercept is independent of the other coefficients, and the basis center is zero in the scaled coordinate. An ordinary Gaussian marginal-likelihood calculation gives $\sigma_f = 5.625$, $\ell = 0.3034$, and $\sigma_\varepsilon = 0.3703$, which both posterior fits use to isolate the effect of the curvature restriction. The length scale corresponds to about 301 irradiance units, and the residual scale has assimilation units.

The inferential targets are the response $A(q)$, its marginal gain $\frac{\mathrm{d}A}{\mathrm{d}q}(q)$, and changes in that gain within the observed range. We report derivatives on the physical irradiance scale, applying factors $1/d$ and $1/d^2$ to first and second derivatives in the scaled coordinate. The concavity restriction makes marginal gain nonincreasing while allowing it to become negative, and imposes no finite saturation level beyond the fitted interval.

We fit the concave model by applying the convexity sampler to $-A$ and the negated responses, and obtain the unconstrained comparison by direct Gaussian simulation. Sampling settings, convergence diagnostics, and posterior predictive assessment are given in the supplementary material.

The response and derivative panels in Figure 2 show different effects of the constraint. Posterior mean responses are close at many observed irradiances, but the unconstrained marginal gain can increase within the range and has substantially wider pointwise intervals at high irradiance. Concavity imposes nonincreasing marginal gain on each posterior curve, so the ordering holds for the individual curves whose uncertainty the right panel summarizes.

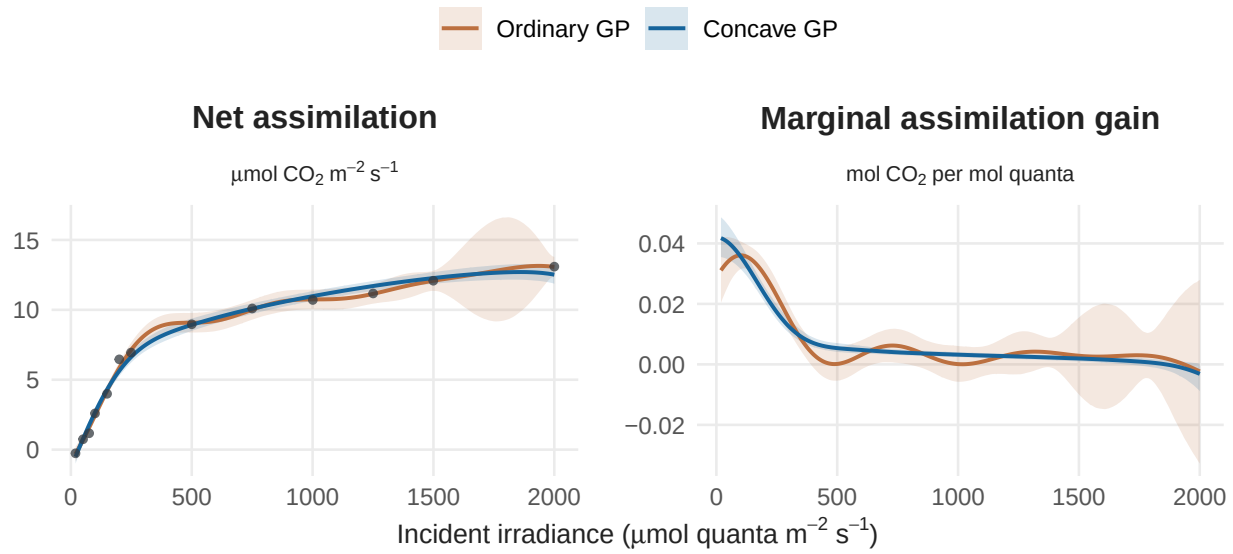


Figure 2: Posterior comparison for 13 net assimilation measurements from one Arctic Eriophorum angustifolium leaf. The left panel shows net assimilation in μmol CO_2 $m^{-2}s^{-1}$, with observations in black. The right panel shows its derivative with respect to incident irradiance, in mol CO_2 per mol quanta. Orange and blue lines are ordinary Gaussian and concavity-conditioned posterior means, with shaded pointwise 95% equal-tail credible intervals for the latent quantities. Both fits use the same covariance and noise parameters and the same rank-24 HSGP expansion.

Table 4 gives selected response and derivative summaries. For example, the assimilation increase from 500 to 1,500 irradiance units has concave posterior mean 3.35 and 95% equal-tail interval $(2.73, 3.99)$. The corresponding unconstrained mean is 3.00 with interval $(2.00, 4.01)$, all in assimilation units. The 95% intervals for the difference in marginal gain between 100 and 1,500 are positive under both fits, so the ordinary Gaussian analysis already supports diminishing gain for

this pair of irradiances. Conditioning extends that ordering to the entire interval while reducing posterior uncertainty about marginal gain at high irradiance.

Quantity	Unconstrained	Concave
$A(100)$	2.46 (2.11, 2.80)	2.67 (2.38, 2.97)
$A(500)$	9.08 (8.38, 9.78)	8.92 (8.49, 9.38)
$A(1{,}500)$	12.08 (11.36, 12.80)	12.27 (11.86, 12.70)
$\frac{\mathrm{d}A}{\mathrm{d}q}(100)$	0.0361 (0.0315, 0.0407)	0.0357 (0.0316, 0.0399)
$\frac{\mathrm{d}A}{\mathrm{d}q}(1{,}500)$	0.0029 (-0.0099, 0.0155)	0.0019 (0.0010, 0.0028)
$\frac{\mathrm{d}A}{\mathrm{d}q}(100) - \frac{\mathrm{d}A}{\mathrm{d}q}(1{,}500)$	0.0332 (0.0197, 0.0467)	0.0338 (0.0295, 0.0381)
$A(1{,}500) - A(500)$	3.00 (2.00, 4.01)	3.35 (2.73, 3.99)

Table 4: Posterior means with pointwise 95% equal-tail credible intervals for the leaf light-response model in Equation (17), with arguments measured in μmol quanta $\mathrm{m}^{-2}\mathrm{s}^{-1}$. Response values and their differences have units μmol CO_2 $\mathrm{m}^{-2}\mathrm{s}^{-1}$, while derivatives and their difference have units mol CO_2 per mol quanta. Both columns use the same covariance and noise estimates, with the concave column additionally conditioning on nonpositive curvature throughout the observed range.

The upper endpoint also reveals the limits of a physiological interpretation. Only 4.6% of concave draws have a nonnegative slope at the highest measured irradiance, even though assimilation increases between the two highest observed irradiances. The inferred decline near the endpoint depends on the curvature restriction and stationary prior, and cannot by itself establish photoinhibition in this leaf.

The example illustrates how a stipulated curvature restriction changes derivative inference for one sequence, whose observation frame does not support conclusions about dark respiration or a species response. Likewise, the analysis does not establish an irradiance optimum independently of the shape assumption.

6 Discussion

This paper develops a common conditioning construction for positivity, monotonicity, and convexity in the Laplacian eigenfunction expansion. The conditioning events themselves are established in constrained GP regression. Their representation here is specific to the HSGP model: it uses the existing oscillatory basis and kernel-derived Gaussian prior to express each whole-interval event through one coefficient, including joint restrictions when a suitable common direction is available. This differs from conditioning at selected locations (Da Veiga and Marrel, 2012, 2020) and from choosing a basis whose coefficient inequalities directly ensure shape (Maatouk and Bay, 2017; López-Lopera et al., 2018). The representation supports joint inference for the curve and its derivatives and separates the definition of the conditioned posterior from the numerical evaluation of its threshold.

The approximation theory connects this finite construction to conditioning the underlying GP. For the individual constraints, the connection holds under the stated spectral assumptions as both padding and frequency cutoff increase, giving a basis for using finite expansions to approximate the corresponding constrained process. The joint construction is exact within the finite expansion, while the convergence theorem covers the individual restrictions.

The practical cost of the representation comes from evaluating a global threshold at each posterior-density calculation. Its maximizing location can change with the coefficients, creating kinks that matter for gradient-based sampling even when the marginal law is strongly log-concave. The threshold-error analysis controls the posterior change caused by conservative evaluation, while sampler accuracy and computational cost remain separate considerations. Developing samplers that exploit this geometry while accommodating the nonsmooth threshold is a useful direction for further work.

The mercury and leaf applications show that shape restrictions can substantially change derivative inference even when the fitted response curves remain similar. These changes matter because the derivatives determine the inferred mercury concentration and marginal carbon assimilation, respectively. Comparing the constrained and ordinary Gaussian posteriors makes the contribution of the shape assumption explicit in both the estimates and their uncertainty. The construction thus connects scientifically motivated restrictions to joint inference for the response and its derivatives, with the chosen constraint enforced throughout the interval.

Declarations

Availability of data and materials

The mercury lidar observations are distributed as the `lidar` data set in SemiPar, version 1.0-4.2. The leaf gas-exchange observations are available from the Rogers et al. (2019) data release. The implementation and worked examples are available in the public project repository.

Competing interests

Not applicable.

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Authors' contributions

Andreas Kryger Jensen developed the methodology, established the theoretical results, implemented the computations, performed the analyses, and wrote the manuscript.

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